LOW TIDE RADIO

Written by

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EXT. OPEN SEA - NIGHT (1999)

FADE IN:

Black water. Lightning, and we see it: a sea the colour of engine oil, running in long hills.

AERIAL: ELEVEN FISHING BOATS SCATTERED ACROSS THE SWELL, MASTHEAD LIGHTS SWINGING. SOME OF THEM ARE TOO FAR APART.

The LITTLE FLOWER, a wooden thirty-footer with her name in blue on the bow, climbs a wave and drops off the back of it.

In the wheelhouse VARGHESE PILLAI (48), bare-chested under an oilskin, holds the wheel with both arms. His DECKHAND bails with a cut plastic can.

A ship-to-shore set is bolted above the compass, its dial glowing orange. Through the hiss, a woman's voice, unhurried, almost amused.

MARIAMMA (ON RADIO)
Kadalkkara to all boats. Wind west-southwest, forty knots and gusting. Put your bow into it and don't argue with it.

VARGHESE
(keying the handset)
Kadalkkara, Little Flower. We hear you. Where is the Seagull?

MARIAMMA (ON RADIO)
(a beat)
Seagull, Seagull, Kadalkkara. Hamza, give me a light. Give me anything.

Nothing but sea noise.

MARIAMMA (ON RADIO) (CONT'D)
Little Flower, I'll read you the river mouth. Have your pencil ready, Varghese. I know you never have your pencil ready.

Varghese almost smiles. He fishes a pencil stub out of the oilskin and wets it on his tongue.

MARIAMMA (ON RADIO) (CONT'D)
Nine degrees, fifty...

CLOSE ON THE SET'S DIAL. THE NEEDLE SHIVERS, DROPS, LIFTS, DROPS.

Her voice tears into static. Varghese slaps the set.

VARGHESE
(into the handset)
Mariamma. Say again.

A wave comes over the bow, white and enormous, and fills the frame.

INT. COAST RADIO STATION - OPERATIONS ROOM - NIGHT (1999)

A concrete room built for radios. Two transmitter racks, valves glowing behind wire mesh. A steel desk, two microphones, two handsets. A Nagra tape recorder, its quarter-inch reel turning slowly. A wall chart of the coast with pins for boats. The clock says 23:38. Rain hits the shutters like thrown gravel.

MARIAMMA THOMAS (38) works both sets at once, a handset at each ear, marking positions on the chart with a grease pencil. Her wristwatch stands propped against the microphone base where she can see it.

MARIAMMA
(into the left handset)
Morning Star, Kadalkkara. I have you. Stay on this channel.
(into the right)
Little Flower, are you back with me?

Under the desk, on a folded fertiliser sack, YOUNG ANJALI (11) sleeps in her school pinafore, a transistor radio on her chest.

ANGLE ON YOUNG ANJALI. HER EYES OPEN. SHE LISTENS TO HER MOTHER'S FEET ON THE CONCRETE.

YOUNG ANJALI
Amma. Is it the big one?

MARIAMMA
It's a normal one. Sleep, or I'll put you on the air and you can read the weather.

Young Anjali smiles and does not close her eyes.

The door opens. Wind lifts the papers off the desk. JOSEPH D'CRUZ, "JOE", the station chief, younger and thinner than we will know him, stands in the doorway, soaked, holding a telegram in a plastic sleeve.

JOE
Mariamma. It's from the Port.

MARIAMMA
(not looking)
Then read it to the Port. I've got Morning Star in one ear and nobody in the other.

Joe looks at her. He looks at the child under the desk. He steps back and pulls the door shut.

The clock moves to 23:40.

Every light in the room dies at once. The valves fade to nothing. Total black. Only the rain.

In the dark, one small sound: the Nagra, still turning on its own batteries.

YOUNG ANJALI (O.S.)
Amma?

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. SOUNDWAVE STUDIO - BENGALURU - DAY

Silence of another kind. A windowless edit suite, grey foam, a wall of monitors.

ANJALI THOMAS (34) sits too close to the screen in headphones. On her wrist, an old ladies' watch with a cracked crystal. It says 23:52. It always says 23:52.

CLOSE ON THE WAVEFORM: A WOMAN'S VOICE, ZOOMED IN UNTIL EACH BREATH IS A SMALL GREY HILL.

Anjali selects a breath. Deletes it. Crossfades. On the speakers a voice actor says "Whiter than your mother's whites," for clearly the fortieth time.

NIKHIL (40), producer, branded fleece, comes in with two coffees and gives her neither.

STUDIO PRODUCER
Client says she sounds tired.

ANJALI
She is tired. She did it forty times.

STUDIO PRODUCER
So make her not tired. You're the magician.

ANJALI
I take things out. That's the job.
(she plays it back: smooth, airless)
There. Nobody breathes in Bengaluru.

STUDIO PRODUCER
By six?

ANJALI
By five, if you leave.

He leaves. Her phone buzzes face down on the desk. She ignores it. It buzzes again.

INSERT: THE PHONE SCREEN. FATHIMA. THREE MISSED CALLS.

She answers.

FATHIMA (ON PHONE)
Finally. Appachan walked out in the night. The door was open, his chappals still inside. We've been looking since four.

Anjali pulls the headphones off. The client's voice keeps going, tiny, from the desk.

ANJALI
Where have you looked?

FATHIMA (ON PHONE)
The church. The harbour. The bus stand. Kannan's gone too, so at least he has the dog.
(beat)
Latha says try the station.

ANJALI
The station's locked.

FATHIMA (ON PHONE)
He has the keys round his neck, Anju. Twenty years round his neck.
(beat)
And they're knocking it down. There's a notice. Next week.

On the monitor the waveform sits frozen, every breath removed.

ANJALI
I'll get the night bus.

FATHIMA (ON PHONE)
(surprised)
You will?

ANJALI
Call me if he turns up.

She hangs up before Fathima can say anything else.

INT. KSRTC BUS - MOVING - NIGHT

A red KSRTC bus on the highway south. Rain runs sideways along the windows. Passengers asleep with their mouths open.

Anjali, knees up in a window seat, takes a yellow Walkman out of her bag. It is held shut with a rubber band.

INSERT: THE CASSETTE LABEL, IN BLUE BALLPOINT: KDK WEATHER, AUG 98, AMMA.

She puts on the foam earphones and presses play. A four-note jingle on a toy organ, wobbling on old tape.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
(on the cassette)
Good morning, Kadalkkara. This is Mariamma at the coast station with the weather for the boats. Wind northwest, ten knots, swell one metre, low tide at five forty...
(a rustle of paper)
No. Five fourteen. Sorry, Raghavan, don't come and shout at me...

She starts to laugh, helpless, on air.

Anjali presses stop before the laugh ends. She looks at the rain. She looks at the watch. 23:52.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. COAST RADIO STATION - DAWN

WIDE ON THE STATION: A FLAT CONCRETE BOX ON A DUNE, A RUSTED LATTICE MAST TWICE ITS HEIGHT, COCONUT PALMS LEANING AWAY FROM THE SEA.

Demolition tape wound round the chain-link fence. A sun-bleached Port Trust board. Crows along the mast stays.

An autorickshaw pulls away down the sand track and leaves Anjali standing with her bag.

Inside the fence, at the foot of the mast, APPACHAN (71) sits with his back to the steel. White stubble, a wet mundu, a vest. Round his neck, on a coir string, a ring of old iron keys. A brown village dog, KANNAN, lies across his feet like a sandbag.

Outside the fence, a white police jeep. INSPECTOR LATHA MENON (45), khaki, sleeves rolled, drinks tea from a steel tumbler and does not hurry.

LATHA
You came on the night bus.

ANJALI
How do you know?

LATHA
You have the face.
(she nods at the fence)
Three in the morning he climbed that. Seventy-one. My constables can't climb that.

ANJALI
Is he hurt?

LATHA
He's wet. He says he's waiting for the shift to finish.

Anjali ducks through a gap where the mesh has been peeled back from a post. Kannan thumps his tail once and stays put.

ANJALI
Appachan.

He looks at her. Something works behind his eyes and does not find its place.

APPACHAN
You're late. She's been on since six. She hasn't eaten.

Anjali crouches and takes his hand. It is cold and gritty.

ANJALI
Then let's go home and eat. All of us.

He looks up at the mast. The crows shift.

APPACHAN
It's very quiet.

ANJALI
(looking up too)
Yes.

Latha tips the rest of her tea onto the sand.

LATHA
I'll drive you. The dog goes in the back.

INT. THOMAS HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

A small kitchen with a red oxide floor, a wood stove and a gas ring side by side, a calendar stuck on a month long gone.

FATHIMA BEEVI (33), headscarf pushed back, boils milk and tea leaves in a dented pan, then pulls the tea from one tumbler to the other at arm's length, a long brown rope of it in the air.

ANJALI
(from the doorway)
That's how she did it.

FATHIMA
Who do you think taught me? I stood on a stool.

Appachan, dry now, eats rice and fish curry with his fingers. Kannan waits under his chair.

APPACHAN
Sainaba. More fish.

Fathima gives him more fish without blinking.

FATHIMA
(quietly)
Sainaba was my mother. Some days I'm her. Yesterday I was the Bishop.

ANJALI
How long has he been like this?

FATHIMA
Two years. You'd know if you rang on a day that wasn't Christmas.

It lands. Anjali takes it.

On the fridge, under a mango-shaped magnet, a typed notice.

INSERT: THE NOTICE. PORT TRUST, KADALKKARA DIVISION. DEMOLITION OF THE DISUSED COAST RADIO STATION WILL COMMENCE SEVEN DAYS FROM THE DATE OF THIS NOTICE.

ANJALI
Seven days.

FATHIMA
A man came with a clipboard. Suresh Pillai.

ANJALI
Varghese chettan's son.

FATHIMA
He works for the contractor now. He's very happy about it.

APPACHAN
(not looking up)
Nobody is happy.

They both look at him. He goes on eating.

FATHIMA
(at the door)
The radio club meets at the shop tonight. Stay a few days, Anju. Not for him. For me.

She goes. Appachan pushes the fish plate toward Anjali. She takes a piece.

EXT. KADALKKARA HARBOUR - DAY

Noon. Diesel, gulls, crows working the fish scraps, an ice truck reversing with its horn going. Men fold wet nets in long pleats. Boats lie rafted three deep along the wharf: Bismillah, Sea Queen, Ambadi, Jyothi.

Anjali walks through it, a stranger who still knows where every puddle is.

An OLD FISHERMAN mending a net looks up. He stands.

OLD FISHERMAN
Mariamma's girl.

He touches her cheek with two rough fingers, as if to check she is real.

OLD FISHERMAN (CONT'D)
Five fourteen. Low tide. She got it wrong on the radio and laughed. I'm Raghavan. The one she told not to shout at her.

ANJALI
I've got that tape.

OLD FISHERMAN
Then you've got more than me.
(he looks up at the mast on the dune)
That night I was on the Jyothi. We followed Varghese's light in. We never heard her. Not one word.

He sits and goes back to his net.

Anjali climbs the track to the station fence. A SURVEY CREW in hard hats sprays orange crosses and numbers on the walls. A theodolite stands in the sand.

SURESH PILLAI (52), white shirt, contractor's lanyard, reading glasses on a cord, holds a clipboard. He knows exactly who she is.

SURESH
The fence is there for a reason.

ANJALI
I'm on the outside of it.

SURESH
Today.
(to the crew)
Mark the mast footings too.

ANJALI
You sold us ice candy at the church fair.

SURESH
And you took two and paid for one.

ANJALI
I was eleven.

SURESH
I heard about your grandfather. I'm sorry. There's a guard on the gate from tonight. For his safety.

ANJALI
Is anything still inside?

SURESH
Bats. Rust. Asbestos.
(he finally looks at her)
The building is coming down, Anjali. And so is the story. This village has walked past that thing for twenty-three years. That's enough.

He turns back to his clipboard. Anjali looks up at the orange cross on the operations room window.

INT. PORT TRUST OFFICE - DAY

Ceiling fans, green steel cupboards, files tied with red tape in towers on every desk.

Across a desk from Anjali sits MR. KRISHNADAS (50s), Deputy Traffic Manager, a man who has said no so often it has become a kind of manners.

PORT OFFICER
Madam, the building is structurally unsafe. It is in the engineer's report.

ANJALI
I don't want to live in it. I want one hour.

PORT OFFICER
The land is leased to the contractor. It is not mine to give you an hour of.

ANJALI
My mother worked there eleven years. Her things...

PORT OFFICER
Station records went to the regional office in 2004. What is left is debris.
(MORE)

PORT OFFICER (CONT'D)
(he slides a form across)
Form 14, for copies. Six to eight weeks.

ANJALI
It'll be a car park in six to eight weeks.

PORT OFFICER
A container yard.
(a little sorry)
Not my decision, madam.

At the next desk, back half turned, Suresh waits for a stamp on his site schedule. He has heard all of it. Krishnadas stamps the schedule twice. Suresh signs it, caps his pen and stands.

Passing behind Anjali's chair he slows for a second. Then he keeps going.

She folds the form in half, and in half again.

CUT TO:

INT. FATHIMA'S TEA SHOP - NIGHT

A tea shop on the harbour road: a glass case of banana fritters, a copper urn hissing, a fluorescent tube with moths.

Rain ticks on the tin roof. Inside, six radios are tuned to six different stations at once.

After closing. Six KIDS from the school radio club crowd a bench around an old shortwave receiver with a coat-hanger aerial. RAHUL (16), skinny, a soldering iron behind his ear like a pencil, turns the dial like a safecracker. MEENU (12), in a uniform two sizes too big, writes in an exercise book.

MEENU
That's Sri Lanka. Write Sri Lanka.

RAHUL
That's a boat from Kollam asking for cigarettes.

Anjali sits at the corner table with tea she is not drinking. Fathima wipes the counter.

FATHIMA
Rahul. Show her.

RAHUL
(not looking up)
She doesn't want to see.

FATHIMA
She fixes sound for a living. Her headphones cost more than this shop.

Rahul looks at Anjali. Then he brings out from under the bench a round blue biscuit tin. A whip aerial made from a curtain rod sticks out of the lid. The switch is a ceiling fan regulator.

RAHUL
It's a transmitter. Medium wave. One watt, maybe two. We want to read the weather for the boats. Like...
(he stops)
Like before.

Anjali lifts the lid. A nest of wires, a transistor bolted to the tin, a great deal of solder.

ANJALI
This will set the shop on fire.

FATHIMA
It did. Last month.

MEENU
Very small fire.

ANJALI
Your output transistor is touching the tin. It shorts every time it gets warm. And this capacitor is in backwards.

RAHUL
It works backwards.

ANJALI
It works until it explodes.

Six kids look at her. She sighs and holds out her palm without looking at anyone.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
Iron.

Rahul puts the soldering iron in her hand like a theatre nurse.

Twenty minutes on. The tea has gone cold. Anjali blows on a fresh joint.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
Switch it on.

Rahul turns the regulator. Across the shop the receiver gives a clean, empty hum. Rahul leans to the tin's little microphone.

RAHUL
Hello.

From the receiver, half a second later, his own voice: "Hello." The kids shriek.

For a moment Anjali looks almost happy. Then she catches herself.

FATHIMA
(low)
She used to let us do that. In the station. On Sundays.

ANJALI
I remember.

FATHIMA
Do you?

Anjali drinks the cold tea.

INT. THOMAS HOUSE - APPACHAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

A narrow room: a cot, a crucifix, a framed photograph of Mariamma at the station microphone, laughing at someone out of frame. By the door, a nail where the coir string of keys hangs at night. Tonight the keys are round Appachan's neck. Kannan sleeps on the floor.

Anjali sits on a stool by the cot. Appachan's eyes open. They are clear. He knows her.

APPACHAN
(in Malayalam)
മോളേ, ഇങ്ങു വാ. ഇരിക്ക്.

ANJALI
I'm here, Appachan. It's Anjali.

He lifts the coir string over his head with shaking hands and holds out the keys.

APPACHAN
ഈ താക്കോൽ മറിയാമ്മയുടേതാണ്. ഇരുപത് കൊല്ലം ഞാനിത് കഴുത്തിലിട്ട് നടന്നു.

ANJALI
(in Malayalam)
എനിക്ക് വേണ്ട, അപ്പച്ചാ.

APPACHAN
അവരാ മുറി മണ്ണിട്ടു മൂടും. നീയത് സമ്മതിക്കരുത്.

ANJALI
Which room?

He frowns, as if she ought to know. He presses the keys into her palm and folds her fingers over them.

APPACHAN
അവളന്ന് രാത്രി നിർത്തിയില്ല. എനിക്കറിയാം.
ആരും വിശ്വസിച്ചില്ല.

ANJALI
How do you know?

APPACHAN
(looking at the photograph)
എന്റെ റേഡിയോയിൽ ഞാൻ കേട്ടു. പന്ത്രണ്ടു മണിയാകും വരെ.

Anjali looks at the watch on her wrist. 23:52.

ANJALI
ഞാൻ നോക്കാം.

His eyes are already going. His hand finds her wrist, the one with the watch, and holds it.

APPACHAN
നിനക്ക് അവളുടെ കൈയാണ്.

He sleeps. She does not move her wrist. On the floor, Kannan sighs.

INT. COAST RADIO STATION - OPERATIONS ROOM - NIGHT

Dark. A key scrapes in a lock. A steel door shoves inward over grit. Two torch beams: Anjali, the keys wound round her fist, and Rahul in a head torch.

The room from the prologue, twenty-three years on. The transmitter racks gutted, doors hanging. The desk. The wall chart rotted to a brown map of stains. Glass on the floor. Black mould climbing the walls like ferns. A bat goes past their heads.

RAHUL
(whispering)
Why are we whispering?

ANJALI
(whispering)
Because it's a crime.

Her torch moves along the tape shelves on the back wall. Steel shelves, stencilled by month. Every one empty. Clean outlines in the dust where boxes stood.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
They cleared it.

RAHUL
Regional office. Form 14. Fathima aunty told the whole village about Form 14.

Anjali goes to the desk and puts her hand flat where the microphone stood. She kneels and looks underneath. The space where a girl could sleep. A fertiliser sack rotted to lace. She stays there.

Rahul has opened a side panel of the big transmitter cabinet with a screwdriver, more from habit than hope.

RAHUL (CONT'D)
Chechi.

Wedged behind the dead valves, a square biscuit box, warped and stained. Rahul works it out and lifts the lid.

A reel of quarter-inch tape on a plastic hub. The tape has swollen to a dull brown, bloomed white with salt at the edges.

CLOSE ON THE REEL LABEL: 14-11-1999.

Round, quick handwriting. Under the date, smaller: KDK ops, log tape, M.

RAHUL (CONT'D)
That's the night.

ANJALI
Don't touch the tape. Close the box.

He closes it. She takes it from him with both hands.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
(barely)
She hid it.

RAHUL
From who?

Outside, a whistle. Sharp and close.

EXT. COAST RADIO STATION - NIGHT

A GUARD (60s), a retired soldier in a security company shirt, swings a long flashlight along the fence and blows his whistle again.

GUARD
Who's there? I have a stick!

Anjali and Rahul come out of the station door low and fast. She pushes the biscuit box inside her shirt and holds it there with one arm.

GUARD (CONT'D)
Stop! The police are coming!

RAHUL
(running)
No they're not!

GUARD
They're coming tomorrow!

Through the gap in the fence and into the coconut grove. Moonlight in stripes between the trunks. Fronds crack underfoot. The flashlight beam swings across the palms behind them.

Rahul's bicycle leans against a palm. He jumps on and pedals twice. The chain comes off with a clank.

RAHUL
No, no, no...

ANJALI
Push it!

They run with the bicycle between them, chain dragging, bell ringing every time the wheel hits a root. Behind them the guard gives up. One last whistle, almost sad.

On the road they stop, bent double, breathing hard. Rahul starts laughing. Anjali tries not to and can't.

RAHUL (CONT'D)
"They're coming tomorrow."

ANJALI
He'll tell Suresh.

RAHUL
Let him.

She takes the box out of her shirt. Still closed. Still dry. She carries it against her chest all the way home, the loose chain ticking on the road beside her.

INT. FISHERIES SCHOOL - RADIO CLUB ROOM - DAY

A classroom nobody else wanted: a bucket under a leak, a blackboard with a half-erased drawing of fish gills, a cupboard of donated electronics, a map of the Arabian Sea edged with postcards from distant radio stations.

Under an anglepoise lamp the reel lies on clean white paper. Anjali, in cotton gloves, lifts one edge of the outer layer with a wooden toothpick. Rahul, Meenu and four other kids lean in. Fathima stands behind them with a tiffin carrier.

CLOSE ON THE OXIDE AS IT LIFTS FROM THE BACKING IN DULL BROWN FLAKES, LIKE SCALES FROM A FISH.

MEENU
It looks like fish.

ANJALI
It's called sticky-shed. The glue that holds the oxide on drinks water. Twenty years by the sea, and this has drunk the sea.

RAHUL
So we can't play it.

ANJALI
Like this, it sticks to the heads and tears. One pass, then nothing.

FATHIMA
So what do we do?

ANJALI
We bake it.

MEENU
Like a cake?

ANJALI
Like a cake nobody eats. Fifty-four degrees for eight hours, then it cools for a day. That drives the water out for a while. Then we play it once, maybe twice, and record everything, because we won't get it again.
(beat)
And I need a quarter-inch machine. A good one.

FATHIMA
The church has a Nagra. Father bought it for the Bishop's visit in ninety-six. It's in the sacristy in a suitcase.

ANJALI
(almost a laugh)
A Nagra. That's the machine she recorded on.

RAHUL
And the oven?

ANJALI
It has to hold fifty-four for eight hours and not move. A kitchen oven swings by twenty. It would cook it.

FATHIMA
(already on her feet)
Babu at the bakery has a convection oven from Dubai. He'll lend it.

ANJALI
Will he?

FATHIMA
He owes me eleven thousand rupees in tea.

INT. FATHIMA'S TEA SHOP - KITCHEN - DAY

The back kitchen, hot and narrow, blackened pans on hooks. Two men from the bakery wheel in a stainless steel convection oven and lift it onto the table. The factory plastic is still on its panel.

Rahul has built an alarm: a thermometer probe pushed through the door seal, wired to a buzzer and a nine-volt battery in a soap dish.

RAHUL
Over fifty-seven, this screams. Under fifty, it also screams. A different scream.

FATHIMA
How different?

RAHUL
You'll know.

Anjali lays the reel flat on a wire rack, hub down, on a paper-lined tray, and slides it in like a surgeon. She closes the door.

INSERT: THE OVEN DISPLAY. 54.

ANJALI
Eight hours. Nobody opens the door. Nobody puts samosas in it.

MEENU
(insulted)
Nobody was going to.

FATHIMA
(who was)
Nobody.

They stand and look at the oven. Its fan hums. Nothing happens. Nothing goes on happening.

MEENU
How long now?

RAHUL
Four minutes.

Fathima sets a plastic chair facing the oven and sits. Rahul brings another. Meenu sits on the floor. Anjali stays standing, arms folded.

FATHIMA
My mother sat like this when my brother was in the incubator.

ANJALI
Did he make it?

FATHIMA
He lives in Sharjah and never calls his mother. So yes.

The alarm gives one small chirp. Everybody jumps. The display still reads 54.

RAHUL
Loose wire.

ANJALI
Fix it.

INT. THOMAS HOUSE - VERANDA - DAY

Late afternoon. A tiled veranda, a low wall, a cane chair, red chillies drying on a string. Beyond the palms the sea flashes in pieces.

Anjali comes up the steps. Appachan sits in the cane chair in his good white shirt, buttoned wrong, his hair combed flat with water. Kannan at his feet. He sees her and his face sets hard.

APPACHAN
മറിയാമ്മേ. What time is it? The shift starts at six. You think the sea waits because you're at the market?

ANJALI
Appachan, I'm...

She stops. She looks at the wrong buttons, at how ready he is.

APPACHAN
Varghese is going out tonight. Eleven boats. You'll be talking to them all night and you haven't eaten.

She sits on the low wall, facing him.

ANJALI
(gently)
The sea is calm tonight, Appachan. Wind off the land. Swell under a metre. Nobody needs me tonight.

APPACHAN
Calm?

ANJALI
Calm. They'll all be home for breakfast.

Something lets go in his shoulders. He sits back.

APPACHAN
Good. Then sit with me, മോളേ.

She takes the coir string of keys from her bag and loops it back over his head. He touches the keys, satisfied. Then she undoes his shirt and buttons it again properly, from the top. He lets her.

INT. FISHERIES SCHOOL - RADIO CLUB ROOM - NIGHT

Blinds down. One lamp. The Nagra sits open on the desk, a silver machine with a big meter needle. Anjali has threaded the baked reel through the heads by hand. A cable runs to a laptop, a pair of studio headphones and a single speaker.

The club sits on the desks and the floor. Fathima stands by the door. Even the ceiling fan is off.

ANJALI
Once I press this, nobody moves. If I say stop, I've already stopped it.

RAHUL
What if it's nothing?

ANJALI
Then it's nothing, and we'll know.

She arms the recording on the laptop. Her finger on the play lever is steady. Her other hand is not. She pushes the lever.

CLOSE ON THE NAGRA'S REELS TURNING. THE TAPE SLIDES OVER THE HEADS AND A LITTLE BROWN DUST LIFTS FROM IT.

Hiss. The room tone of a room that no longer exists. A clock. Rain.

Then, close and warm in the speaker, a woman's laugh.

Meenu grabs Rahul's sleeve.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
(on the tape)
No, Joe, I'm not going to say it like that, they'll think somebody died...

Static swallows her. The meter needle swings and drops. Then, clear:

MARIAMMA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Little Flower, Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara. Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara, do you...

A sound like paper tearing. On the left reel, layers of tape lift away together in one stuck block.

Anjali snaps the lever back. Silence. Nobody moves.

ANJALI
(very quietly)
The second half is stuck to itself. If I pull it, it tears.

She puts both hands flat on the table either side of the Nagra. She is shaking now, all of her.

Fathima comes up behind her and just stands there.

FATHIMA
That was her.

ANJALI
(nodding)
That was her.

MEENU
(whispering)
She was funny.

ANJALI
She was very funny.
(she stares at the reel)
It has to go back in the oven. Longer. I don't know if the second half survives it.

FATHIMA
So we bake it again, Anju.

INT. JOE'S ROOM ABOVE THE TODDY SHOP - DAY

A rented room up an outside stair, above the toddy shop's tin roof. Empty arrack bottles stand along one wall like a fence. A cot made with military neatness. One framed photograph on the wall, turned to face the plaster.

JOE (60), grey, heavy in the face, in a very clean shirt, pours tea into a single glass and gives it to Anjali. He pours nothing for himself.

JOE
You look like her round the mouth. Not the eyes.

ANJALI
I want to ask you about the fourteenth.

JOE
Everybody has asked me about the fourteenth. The Port. The police. A newspaper from Kottayam. I said what I said. It's written down.

ANJALI
I've read it. The main transmitter failed in the storm at 23:40 and you couldn't get it back.

JOE
That's right.

ANJALI
We found a reel.

His hand is on the kettle. It moves, very slightly. The lid rattles.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
In the transmitter cabinet. Her handwriting. The fourteenth.

JOE
(without turning round)
The station tapes went to the regional office in 2004.

ANJALI
Not this one.

He sets the kettle down. His hand is shaking. He puts it in his pocket.

JOE
I'd like you to go now. I'm asking politely, Anjali.

At the door she looks at the photograph turned to the wall.

ANJALI
Is that the station?

JOE
Go home.

She goes. He stands in the middle of the room a long time. Then he kneels and takes a bottle from under the cot.

EXT. ST. ANTONY'S CHURCH - DAY

A seafront church, its white paint eaten by salt. Marigold garlands on the steps. A cloth banner between two palms: 14 November 1999, We Remember.

Two hundred villagers in white, the men in mundus, the women in white saris with black borders. Under a canvas awning a CHOIR of twelve sings a slow hymn to a harmonium.

Anjali stands at the very back by the cycle stand, in a borrowed white churidar. Fathima beside her.

On the church steps Suresh, in white, unfolds a sheet of paper. The choir finishes. There is only the sea.

SURESH
Varghese Pillai.
(beat)
Hamza Kutty.
Sebastian Fernandez.
Thankachan Joseph.
Kunjumon Antony.
Paulose Mathew.
Antony Xavier.
Babu Rajan.

At Hamza's name, Fathima's lips move with his.

SURESH (CONT'D)
Eight men. Three boats. Little Flower, Seagull, Morning Star.
(he folds the paper)
We know what happened to them. We have always known.

Heads turn toward the back. One, then three, then twenty. Toward Anjali.

Suresh does not look at her. He looks at the sea.

Fathima's hand finds Anjali's and holds on.

FATHIMA
(under her breath)
Don't go.

ANJALI
I'm not going anywhere.

INT. POLICE OUTPOST - DAY

One front room with a counter, a wireless set muttering, faded posters. At the back a single cell, its door open, a constable's lunch box on the bunk.

Latha, in reading glasses, turns a typed complaint round so Anjali can read it.

LATHA
Trespass on Port Trust property. Damage to a fence. Theft of one item, unspecified. Your name. Rahul's name, spelled wrong.

ANJALI
The fence was already cut. My grandfather cut it.

LATHA
With what?

ANJALI
His teeth.

Latha almost smiles. She does not.

LATHA
The contractor sends me a letter, I answer the letter. I have to ask you about an unspecified item.

ANJALI
I don't have an unspecified item.

LATHA
Good. Keep not having it.

She gets up, shuts the front door, turns the wireless down. She opens the bottom drawer of her desk with a key from her own key ring and takes out a thin cardboard file, its string tie gone grey. She puts it on the desk. She does not push it across.

INSERT: THE FILE COVER. MISSING PERSON. MARIAMMA THOMAS, 38. KADALKKARA. 15-11-1999.

ANJALI
Why is it in your drawer?

LATHA
Because nobody ever closed it.
(beat)
You read it tonight and it's on my desk at nine tomorrow, or I arrest you for the fence.

Anjali takes the file and holds it on her knees with both hands, the way she held the reel.

ANJALI
Thank you.

LATHA
(glasses back on)
I didn't give you anything. Go away.

CUT TO:

INT. THOMAS HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

One bulb. The file open on the table: a typed statement, a sketch map of the station and the jetty, a carbon copy of a Port Trust incident report. Anjali and Fathima sit side by side.

ANJALI
(reading)
"The transmitter ceased operation at approximately 23:40 owing to storm damage to the main supply. Station chief J. D'Cruz left the premises at approximately 23:50 to seek assistance."

FATHIMA
To seek assistance.

ANJALI
"At approximately 00:05 Operator M. Thomas was seen by the ice plant watchman walking toward the north jetty carrying a lantern."
(she turns the page)
That's the last thing.

FATHIMA
Everybody says what she was doing. She went down to the boats because the station went quiet and it was her fault and she couldn't live with it.

ANJALI
Is that what you say?

Fathima takes off her glasses and lays them on the file.

FATHIMA
My uncle Hamza was on the Seagull.

ANJALI
You never said.

FATHIMA
Not once. Not to you, when you cried in my bed every night for a
(MORE)

FATHIMA (CONT'D)
month. I thought if I said Seagull, you'd hear blame.
(beat)
He taught me to swim. He threw me off the jetty and counted. I came up at seven every time and he'd say, slow, Fathima, the fish are laughing at you.

ANJALI
I'm sorry.

FATHIMA
I'm not telling you so you'll be sorry.
(she taps the time on the page: 23:40)
I've carried this village's tea for twenty-three years. I want to know too.

Anjali puts her hand over Fathima's on the file.

ANJALI
Okay.

EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - DAY

A bright, windy morning. The radio club's kite, a square of old blue fishing net on bamboo with a tail of plastic bags, climbs and holds. A long copper wire runs down the kite line to a stake in the sand.

At the stake, on a plastic chair, sits the club's battered marine transceiver, borrowed off a boat. Anjali kneels beside it. Fathima watches from under a beach umbrella with a flask.

ANJALI
You don't say hello. You say their name, then yours, then you stop and let them answer.

RAHUL
What's our name?

ANJALI
You haven't got one yet. Say radio club.

She hands him the handset. He holds it as if it were hot.

RAHUL
(keying)
Kadalkkara Harbour, Kadalkkara Harbour, this is the radio club. Over.

Static. Wind. Nothing. Meenu's face falls.

ANJALI
Wait.

A gull goes over. Then, flat and bored:

HARBOUR CLERK (ON RADIO)
Radio club, Harbour. What do you want? Over.

One second of silence. Then Rahul and Meenu both start yelling at once.

RAHUL
He answered! Harbour, this is us! We're on the beach! We made a kite!

MEENU
He answered! Rahul, he answered! Tell him about the kite!

The smaller kids scream and run in circles.

HARBOUR CLERK (ON RADIO)
Radio club, take your thumb off the key. Over.

Anjali is laughing. Not politely. Bent over, one hand flat on the sand, laughing the way her mother laughed on the cassette.

Under the umbrella, Fathima sees it and stops pouring.

ANJALI
(wiping her eyes)
Say thank you and say out.

RAHUL
(keying, very formal)
Thank you, Harbour. Radio club, out.

HARBOUR CLERK (ON RADIO)
Go to school. Harbour, out.

INT. THOMAS HOUSE - APPACHAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

Wind. The shutters bang against the wall again and again. Rain blows in across the floor.

Anjali comes in with a torch.

ANJALI
Appachan, the window...

The cot is empty, the sheet thrown back.

ANGLE ON THE NAIL BY THE DOOR. THE COIR STRING OF KEYS IS GONE.

Kannan's lead lies on the floor, a length of nylon rope with an empty loop. Down the passage the front door bangs open and shut.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
Appachan!

She runs. Her torch swings across the photograph of Mariamma, the empty cot.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. KADALKKARA HARBOUR - NIGHT

Rain in sheets. Waves burst on the harbour wall and come down on the road like thrown buckets.

Fishermen in plastic sheets with torches and lanterns shout names into the wind. Kids on bicycles ride the road along the wall, ringing their bells.

RAHUL
(on his bicycle)
Appachan! Kannan!

Fathima, a sari over her head, shines a torch into wheelhouses.

FATHIMA
Raghavan chetta, the net sheds!

Anjali comes running, soaked through.

ANJALI
The station?

FATHIMA
Latha's there. He isn't. Not the church, not the bus stand, not the ice plant. Anju, he isn't anywhere.

Headlights. A contractor's flatbed site truck, a generator and two folded floodlight towers on the back, stops with its wipers going. Suresh jumps down in a rain jacket with two of his CREW.

SURESH
(to his crew)
Towers up. One on the wharf, one at the root of the breakwater.

The generator coughs and roars. The lights come up hard and white, and all at once the harbour has edges.

SURESH (CONT'D)
(to the fishermen)
Mani, take five men north to the river. Joy, go south. Nobody goes on the wall without a rope.

Nobody argues. They go. Suresh sees Anjali, rain pouring off them both.

SURESH (CONT'D)
When did you last see him?

ANJALI
Nine. Asleep. The dog was with him.

Suresh looks past the lights at the long black arm of the breakwater. Its far end is under white water.

SURESH
He used to stand out there when we were kids. With a lantern, waiting for the boats.

ANJALI
That was twenty years ago.

SURESH
Not for him.

He is already walking.

EXT. HARBOUR BREAKWATER - NIGHT

WIDE ON THE BREAKWATER: A LONG SPINE OF CONCRETE TETRAPODS RUNNING INTO THE STORM, FLOODLIT AT THE ROOT, BLACK AT THE FAR END. EVERY FEW SECONDS A WAVE GOES OVER IT WHOLE.

Suresh climbs onto the first tetrapod with a coil of rope. Anjali scrambles up behind him.

SURESH
Stay here and hold the rope.

ANJALI
He's my grandfather.

SURESH
He was my father's friend. Hold the rope.

He throws her the end and goes out, crouching, three points of contact. A wave comes. He drops flat and holds on. It goes over him. He is still there. He goes on.

On the last block stands Appachan, in his vest and mundu, soaked through, swinging a torch in slow arcs out to sea. Kannan is pressed against his legs, barking at the water.

APPACHAN
(shouting at the sea)
Here! This way! Varghese! The river mouth!

Suresh reaches him. Appachan fights him, surprisingly strong.

APPACHAN (CONT'D)
Let go! They can't see the light!

SURESH
Appachan, it's Suresh. Varghese's boy.

Appachan stops. Water streams down both their faces.

APPACHAN
(confused)
Your father's out there.

A long moment.

SURESH
I know. He's coming in. He saw your light. They all saw it.

APPACHAN
He saw it?

SURESH
He saw it. Come home now.

Appachan's legs give. Suresh wraps him in his rain jacket and lifts him. An old man weighing nothing.

Behind them a wave rises, the biggest yet.

ANJALI
(at the root)
Suresh!

It breaks. White over everything. The torch is torn from Appachan's hand.

UNDERWATER: THE TORCH TUMBLES DOWN THROUGH GREEN-BLACK WATER, ITS BEAM TURNING OVER AND OVER, FADING.

The water drains off the blocks. Suresh is still there, on his knees, Appachan in his arms. Kannan scrambles up out of a gap and shakes himself.

Suresh walks back, block by block. Anjali hauls in the rope hand over hand as he comes, as if she were pulling them both in. She takes Appachan's face in her hands.

APPACHAN
(eyes closed, teeth chattering)
He saw the light.

SURESH
Hospital. Now.

INT. TALUK HOSPITAL - WARD - NIGHT

A long men's ward. Twenty iron beds, ceiling fans, half of them turning. Somebody coughing. Somebody's radio playing old film songs very low.

Appachan sleeps under two hospital blankets, a drip in the back of his hand, oxygen prongs in his nose.

A NURSE (40s) checks the drip and writes on the chart.

NURSE
His temperature is coming up. Old people get cold and forget how to get warm.
(she hands Anjali a plastic bag)
His things.

A wet vest, a mundu, and the coir string of keys. Anjali takes out the keys and holds them.

NURSE (CONT'D)
Only one person stays the night.

ANJALI
I'm staying.

The nurse looks at Suresh, soaked, sitting on the next bed in a puddle.

NURSE
Bed twelve is for a real patient.
Get off it.

Suresh gets up and stands against the wall. The nurse moves on.

ANJALI
Thank you.

SURESH
Don't.
(he looks at Appachan)
He used to take me out on his boat on Sundays, when my father was drinking. Told me I had soft hands and I'd better study.

ANJALI
You got the ice candy job.

He almost laughs. It doesn't come out.

SURESH
My father's boat had the best set in the fleet. A Japanese set. He paid it off over three years.
(he looks at his hands)
That night he could hear Kollam. He could hear a ship off Colombo. And he couldn't hear Kadalkkara. Because your mother had gone off the air.

ANJALI
You don't know that.

SURESH
Every skipper who came home said it. The station went quiet at twenty to twelve. They followed my father's lantern to the river mouth. Then he went back out for the Seagull, alone, because nobody was on the radio telling anybody anything.

ANJALI
And you blame her.

SURESH
I was on the beach with a torch, like an idiot. Like him tonight. I blamed God for a year. Then the sea. Then I got tired and blamed the person who was supposed to be talking.
(beat)
It's easier than it sounds.

Anjali unbuckles the watch and holds it out. He does not take it.

ANJALI
It was hers. It stopped at eight minutes to twelve. She put it on my wrist that night and told me to wind it at midnight. I fell asleep.
(she buckles it back on)
She didn't stop at twenty to twelve, Suresh. There's a reel.

SURESH
The thing you stole.

ANJALI
The thing she hid.

Appachan stirs and sleeps again. They both watch him.

INT. TALUK HOSPITAL - CORRIDOR - DAWN

Grey light at the end of a long corridor. A vending machine hums. Relatives asleep on benches and on newspapers on the floor.

Suresh gets two paper cups of tea from the machine and hands one to Anjali. His shirt has dried on him in creases.

SURESH
What's on the reel?

ANJALI
A laugh. Half a sentence. "Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara." The rest is stuck. It's baking again now, in a bakery oven, with a sixteen-year-old's alarm on it.

SURESH
That's your evidence.

ANJALI
I'm not making a case. I want to hear the end of it.

SURESH
The excavator comes the day after tomorrow. It's booked. It's paid for. The Port wants the land clear, and so do I.
(beat)
I'll look away for one day. Today, until six. My guard takes a long lunch. If there's nothing in there, you let it go. You let him let it go. You let me let it go.

ANJALI
And if there's something?

SURESH
Then I'll be standing next to you when you find it.

She holds out her cup. He taps his against it. Neither of them drinks.

INT. COAST RADIO STATION - TAPE ROOM - DAY

A basement under the operations room, down a concrete stair. Black water stands knee-deep. Daylight falls through a single grille in one slanting bar. Swollen tape boxes float everywhere, open and empty.

Anjali wades in wearing rubber boots, a torch in her hand. Rahul follows in shorts and a head torch. Suresh stays at the top of the stairs in his site boots, a hard hat in his hand.

SURESH
Mind the wiring. There's no power, but mind it anyway.

Anjali pushes a floating box aside. Empty. Another. Empty.

RAHUL
What are we looking for?

ANJALI
Appachan said they'd bury the room.
(she looks up at the ceiling)
I thought he meant upstairs.

ANGLE ON THE UNDERSIDE OF THE CONCRETE STAIRS, BLACK AND DRIPPING. SOMETHING SQUARE AND OLIVE GREEN IS BOLTED UP UNDER THE TREADS.

Rahul crouches until the water reaches his waist and ducks under the stairs.

RAHUL
Chechi. There's a box.

An army surplus ammunition box, bolted under the stairs with two rusted brackets. A padlock.

SURESH
(coming down three steps)
That's a fuse box.

RAHUL
It's an ammunition box. My uncle keeps his fish hooks in one.

Anjali pulls the coir string of keys from under her shirt. One key. Another. The third is small and brass, newer than the rest. It turns.

Together she and Rahul ease the box off its brackets. She holds it up clear of the water.

Suresh comes the rest of the way down into the water without seeming to notice he has done it.

She sets the box on a step and lifts the lid. A rubber seal sighs. Inside, dry, wrapped in a plastic rice sack, a ledger bound in green cloth. Stencilled on the cover: KDK Coast Radio. Station Log. 1999.

Nobody speaks.

INT. COAST RADIO STATION - OPERATIONS ROOM - DAY

Daylight through the broken shutters across the old desk. Anjali sits where her mother sat, the logbook open. Rahul perches on the desk. Suresh stands at the window, not quite in the room.

The pages are ruled in columns: time, station, traffic, operator. A different hand for each shift. Anjali turns to the fourteenth of November and runs her finger down.

ANJALI
(reading)
Eighteen hundred. Mariamma on watch.

18:00 M. THOMAS ON WATCH. WEATHER TO ALL STATIONS. WIND W 20 KNOTS AND RISING.

21:30 ELEVEN BOATS AT SEA, ALL REPORTING: LITTLE FLOWER, SEAGULL, MORNING STAR, BISMILLAH, SEA QUEEN, AMBADI, JYOTHI, MOTHER MARY, ST. ANTONY, KAIRALI, POURNAMI.

22:50 CYCLONE WARNING RELAYED FROM DISTRICT. ALL BOATS ADVISED TO RETURN.

23:15 LITTLE FLOWER AND SEAGULL REPORT HEAVY SWELL, 9 MILES WSW.

23:32 SEAGULL NOT ANSWERING. LITTLE FLOWER STANDING BY.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
Twenty-three thirty-two. Seagull not answering.

Her finger stops. The next entry is in another hand, heavier, pressed hard into the paper.

23:40 MAIN POWER CUT BY ORDER. J. D'CRUZ.

Suresh crosses the room in three steps and reads it over her shoulder.

SURESH
By order.

ANJALI
It doesn't say storm damage.

Below Joe's line, in the round quick hand from the reel label, a single small entry.

23:41 ON BATTERY.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
(almost a whisper)
On battery.

RAHUL
What does that mean?

ANJALI
It means somebody switched her off, and she didn't stay off.

Suresh puts his hard hat down on the desk as if it were made of glass. He looks at the doorway.

SURESH
Joe D'Cruz said it was the storm. He said it to my mother in our front room. He held her hand when he said it.

Anjali closes the logbook and stands.

ANJALI
Where does he drink now?

SURESH
Same place he always did.

CUT TO:

EXT. TODDY SHOP - NIGHT

A palm-thatched toddy shop at the edge of the backwater. A yard of packed earth under a mango tree, long tables, a string of bare bulbs, clay pots of toddy, plates of tapioca and fish curry. Twenty DRINKERS, fishermen mostly. A cassette player on the counter plays an old film song.

Joe sits alone at the end of a table with a glass and a plate he has not touched.

Anjali walks into the yard with the logbook against her chest. Suresh stays at the gate.

Heads turn. Women do not come in here. The talk dies table by table. Somebody turns the cassette player off.

ANJALI
Joe.

JOE
Not here.

ANJALI
You told me it's written down. You were right.

She opens the logbook on the table in front of him, on top of his tapioca, and says it from memory, loud enough for the yard.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
"Twenty-three forty. Main power cut by order. J. D'Cruz."
(beat)
That's your hand. Whose order, Joe?

The yard is silent. A frog in the backwater. The bulbs buzz.

Joe stands, unsteady. He empties every note from his wallet onto the counter.

JOE
(to the whole yard)
Everybody's drinks.

Nobody moves.

At the gate Suresh does not step aside. Joe has to turn sideways to get past him. Neither speaks.

Joe goes out to an old cream Ambassador parked under a streetlight. He tries the key twice. The engine catches.

ANJALI
(to herself)
He's drunk.

The Ambassador pulls out, its one working headlight sweeping across the yard and away.

EXT. LIGHTHOUSE ROAD - NIGHT

A narrow coast road on a ridge between the sea and the backwater. The lighthouse beam sweeps over it every twelve seconds.

The Ambassador weaves onto the gravel shoulder, corrects too hard, drifts across the centre line. A cow stands in the road in the headlight, chewing, a bell round its neck. The car swerves round it with a long horn and a spray of gravel. The cow does not move.

Ahead, the road bends sharply over a drop to the rocks.

A blue light behind. Latha's jeep overtakes on the outside, cuts in and stops across the road. The Ambassador slides on the wet gravel and stops a metre short of the jeep's door.

Latha walks to the driver's window. Joe sits with both hands on the wheel, looking straight ahead. She reaches in, switches off the engine, takes the keys out of the ignition and puts them in her pocket. Neither of them says a word.

She opens his door and waits. After a long moment he gets out.

LATHA
(finally)
Third time.

JOE
I know.

LATHA
I never wrote up the first two.

JOE
I know.

The lighthouse beam goes over them.

LATHA
Get in the jeep.

INT. POLICE OUTPOST - CELL - NIGHT

The single cell. Its door stands open. It has never been locked. Joe sits on the concrete bunk under a bare bulb with a steel tumbler of black coffee.

Latha sits on a plastic chair in the doorway of the cell. Anjali stands in the outer room by the counter, the logbook under her arm. She has come no closer.

LATHA
Joe. She's here.

JOE
(to his coffee)
At twenty past eleven a telegram came from the Port office. A boy rode a bicycle through that rain.

ANJALI
I saw you. In the doorway.

JOE
(looking up for the first time)
You were asleep.

ANJALI
I wasn't.

He takes that in.

JOE
Shut down the main transmitter at 23:40. Lightning risk. The Port had just put up a new signal tower in the same ground as our mast. Forty lakhs. If lightning came down our mast and burned their tower, somebody would have to explain it.
(beat)
It said it was an order. It had a number on it. I had a loan on the house. I pulled the breaker myself and I wrote it in the book. I thought, one day somebody will read this and know it was them, not me.
(beat)
Then I tore the telegram up and told everyone it was the storm. Because nobody reads the book.

ANJALI
What did she do?

JOE
There was an emergency set. An old army battery set, two car batteries, on the emergency aerial on the roof. Half the range. Less.
(beat)
She wired it up in the dark by a candle. I told her she'd be sacked. I told her she'd be killed if lightning hit the mast. I said, Anjali is here. Think of Anjali.

Anjali's hand tightens on the logbook.

JOE (CONT'D)
She gave me the book and told me to write whatever I liked. Then she put the headphones on and started calling Varghese.

LATHA
And you?

JOE
I went home.
(beat)
I sat in my kitchen with the radio on and couldn't hear her. The set was too weak to reach the village. I thought she was sitting in the dark talking to nobody.

ANJALI
She wasn't talking to nobody.

JOE
(very quietly)
I went back at one. The candle was out. The set was cold. The lantern was gone off its hook. And she was gone.

A long silence. The bulb buzzes.

ANJALI
You let them say it was her. For twenty-three years.

JOE
Yes.

He reaches out and holds the bars of the open cell door. Not to keep himself in. Just to hold on to something.

CLOSE ON JOE'S HANDS ON THE BARS, KNUCKLES WHITE.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. COAST RADIO STATION - OPERATIONS ROOM - NIGHT (1999)

Younger hands, gripping a doorframe. Joe, 1999, soaked, in the doorway.

One candle on the desk, stuck in its own wax on a saucer. The valve racks dead. Rain.

Mariamma kneels beside an olive green emergency set, a heavy steel box with a handle, two car batteries next to it. She clips a lead to a battery by feel. A small blue crack of sparks. She does not flinch.

JOE
Mariamma, leave it. It's an order from the Port.

MARIAMMA
The Port isn't out there.

JOE
If lightning comes down that mast, it comes down that aerial and into you.

MARIAMMA
Then hold the candle further away.

She clips the second lead. A green lamp on the set glows. A hum.

Under the desk, Young Anjali, wide awake, holds her transistor against her chest.

POV YOUNG ANJALI: HER MOTHER'S FACE IN THE CANDLELIGHT, LIT GREEN FROM BELOW BY THE LAMP ON THE SET.

JOE (CONT'D)
Anjali is here. Think of Anjali. Come home.

MARIAMMA
I am thinking of Anjali.

She stands, takes the logbook off the desk and pushes it into his chest.

MARIAMMA (CONT'D)
Here. Write whatever you like. Then go home, Joe. Somebody should be dry tonight.

He writes, standing, the book braced against the doorframe. He lays it on the desk and goes out into the rain without looking back.

Mariamma reads his line. She writes one short line under it. She checks the Nagra. Its reels still turn on their own batteries.

She kneels by the desk. Young Anjali looks out at her.

YOUNG ANJALI
Are we in trouble?

MARIAMMA
Joe's in trouble. We're working.

She buckles the wristwatch onto her daughter's thin wrist, on the last hole. It is still too big.

MARIAMMA (CONT'D)
You're the clock now. At midnight you wind it, and you tell me it's twelve.

YOUNG ANJALI
What happens at twelve?

MARIAMMA
Low tide.

She puts on the headphones and takes up the handset of the battery set.

MARIAMMA (CONT'D)
(into the handset)
Little Flower, Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara. Varghese, you'll have to listen hard. I'm very small tonight.

Under the desk, Young Anjali looks at the watch. Her eyes begin to close.

INT. FISHERIES SCHOOL - RADIO CLUB ROOM - NIGHT

The lamp. The Nagra. The reel has been baked a second time, for twelve hours, and has cooled. The club sits on the floor. Fathima at the door.

ANJALI
It came apart this afternoon. Layer by layer, with a toothpick.

RAHUL
Does it play?

ANJALI
We find out.

She presses the lever. The reels turn.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
(on the tape, small, through heavy noise)
Little Flower, Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara, on battery. Varghese, you'll have to listen hard. I'm very small tonight.

A long crackle. Meenu puts her hand over her mouth.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
(on the tape, distorted, far away)
Kadalkkara, Little Flower. Weak, but I have you. Go.

Anjali's hand moves to the fader and holds the level steady.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
River mouth. Nine fifty-eight north, seventy-six fifteen east. Bring them in on the church tower and the ice plant chimney in a line. Keep to the north side of the bar. Over.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
Little Flower copies. Church and chimney. North side. I'll take them in. I'll light the boats.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
Light them, Varghese. Tell them it's you. They'll follow you. They never listen to me.

Rahul is crying silently, his hands in his lap. Meenu leans against his shoulder. Anjali's eyes stay on the meter. Her hand stays on the fader. Steady.

MARIAMMA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Seagull, Seagull, Kadalkkara. Hamza, give me a light.

At the door, Fathima puts her hand flat against the wall.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
Kadalkkara, Little Flower. Eight boats inside the bar. I'm going back for Hamza. Mariamma, I'm going back.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
Varghese, don't...
(a long pause)
Go carefully. I'll be here.

Her voice is thinning now as the battery drops, as if she were walking away down a corridor.

MARIAMMA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Kadalkkara. Battery's going. Time is twenty-three fifty-one. Anjali's asleep.
(very faint)
I'll put the lantern on the jetty for you, Varghese. Look for the lantern.

Hiss. Only hiss. The meter needle lies down flat.

Anjali looks at the watch on her wrist. 23:52.

She lets the reel run out. The tail of the tape flaps round on the take-up spool. Tick. Tick. Tick.

FATHIMA
(barely)
She said Hamza.

ANJALI
She said everybody's name.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. OPEN SEA - LITTLE FLOWER - NIGHT (1999)

The wheelhouse. Varghese has the handset pressed to his ear, one arm round the wheel. With the pencil stub he writes on the back of his hand: 958 7615.

VARGHESE
(into the handset)
Nine fifty-eight, seventy-six fifteen. Church and chimney.

MARIAMMA (ON RADIO)
(tiny, far)
That's it. North side.

He takes a lit hurricane lantern off its hook and goes out on deck into the rain.

POV VARGHESE: MASTHEAD LIGHTS SCATTERED OVER THE SWELL, SOME NEAR, SOME FAR, ALL OF THEM LOST.

He climbs onto the wheelhouse roof, one hand on the mast, and swings the lantern in a slow arc over his head. The fishermen's signal. Follow me.

One light turns. Then another. Then five. The boats come round and fall in behind the Little Flower in a ragged line.

His deckhand shouts and points. Far off to the west, a hull rides low with no lights, side-on to the sea. The Seagull. Drifting.

Varghese looks at the line of boats behind him, nearly home. Then at the Seagull. He drops back into the wheelhouse and takes the wheel.

VARGHESE (CONT'D)
(to the deckhand)
Hold on to something.

He turns the Little Flower away from the river mouth, back into the dark.

The handset swings on its cord.

MARIAMMA (ON RADIO)
(barely there)
Look for the lantern.

CUT TO:

INT. SURESH'S HOUSE - DAY

A small, very neat concrete house. A polished red floor. Plastic flowers. On the wall, in a gilt frame, a photograph of the Little Flower on her launch day, men crowded on her deck with garlands. In the middle of them a younger Varghese, laughing.

Anjali sets a small digital recorder and a pair of closed headphones on the dining table. Suresh stands across the table from her.

ANJALI
It's eleven minutes. His voice comes in at four. I took a little of the hiss down. I didn't cut anything.

SURESH
Why not?

ANJALI
It isn't mine to cut.

She goes out. The door closes behind her.

Suresh stands for a while. Then he sits, puts on the headphones and presses play.

Very faint, leaking from the earcups:

VARGHESE (V.O.)
(through the headphones)
Little Flower copies. I'll take them in. I'll light the boats.

POV ANJALI, THROUGH THE WINDOW FROM THE FRONT STEP: SURESH AT THE TABLE IN THE HEADPHONES, VERY STILL. SLOWLY HE PUTS ONE HAND FLAT ON THE TABLE AND LEAVES IT THERE.

BACK TO SCENE.

The recording ends. Suresh takes the headphones off and lays them down very gently. He goes to the photograph and straightens it, though it was already straight.

He opens the front door. Anjali sits on the step with her back to him.

SURESH
He sounds young.

ANJALI
He was younger than you are now.

SURESH
(a beat)
He said, I'm going back. He knew.

ANJALI
They both knew.

SURESH
Come inside. I'll make tea. I make terrible tea.

She gets up and goes in.

INT. PORT TRUST OFFICE - DAY

The same fans. Krishnadas at his desk. Suresh sits in the chair where Anjali sat.

PORT OFFICER
Mr. Pillai, your own company booked the excavator. The container yard contractor starts piling on the twentieth. If I move your date, I am explaining to Ernakulam why.

SURESH
One week.

PORT OFFICER
Not one day.

SURESH
There is a station log that says the Port ordered that transmitter shut down at 23:40 on the fourteenth of November 1999. In a cyclone. With eleven boats out.

Krishnadas stops writing and looks up properly for the first time.

PORT OFFICER
(carefully)
If there is such a document, there will be an inquiry. Inquiries take nine years. The building comes down tomorrow either way.

SURESH
I understand.
(he slides a typed sheet across)
Then sign this. The site generator, the truck and two of my men, tonight, on the beach below the station. One night.

PORT OFFICER
For what?

SURESH
A listening.

Krishnadas signs the sheet without reading it and stamps it.

PORT OFFICER
(handing it back)
My father was on the Jyothi. He came home.

EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - DUSK

The sun going down red into the sea. Fishing boats pulled up in a long row. Kids on bamboo ladders string paper lanterns and kerosene lanterns between the masts, a line of small lights the length of the beach.

Fathima at a trestle table with her copper urn and a stack of steel tumblers. Rahul and Meenu run cable from the Nagra to two big loudspeakers on bamboo stands, borrowed from the church festival.

The contractor's generator truck grinds onto the sand, two of Suresh's crew pushing at the tailboard. Suresh walks backward in front of it, guiding it in.

SURESH
Left. Stop. Chock it.

RAHUL
How much power is that?

SURESH
Enough for this beach and half the village.

RAHUL
We need about forty watts.

SURESH
Then you'll have a lot left over.

Fathima holds out a tumbler of tea to Suresh. It is the first thing she has ever handed him.

FATHIMA
You came.

SURESH
I brought the lights.

FATHIMA
That's what I said.

At the far end of the beach, where the lanterns stop, a man in a clean shirt stands alone with his hands in his pockets. Joe. He walked here. He comes no closer.

Fathima looks at him a long moment. Then she pours a second tumbler and sends Meenu down the beach with it. Joe takes it.

JOE
(to Meenu)
Thank her for me.

INT. THOMAS HOUSE - APPACHAN'S ROOM - DUSK

Anjali buttons Appachan's good white shirt, from the top, the right way. He is thinner since the hospital. The keys hang on their nail by the door.

APPACHAN
Is she on tonight?
(beat)
മറിയാമ്മ. Is she on shift?

Anjali's fingers stop on a button.

ANJALI
(a breath)
ഉവ്വ്, അപ്പച്ചാ. She's on tonight. It's her last shift. We're all going down to the beach to listen to her.

APPACHAN
The sea?

ANJALI
Calm.

APPACHAN
She'll be embarrassed.

ANJALI
(smiling)
She'll laugh.

APPACHAN
She always laughs.

He stands. Kannan gets up off the floor too. Appachan takes the keys from the nail and hangs them round his neck. He stands with them a moment. Then he lifts them off and hangs them back on the nail.

APPACHAN (CONT'D)
Leave them. We won't need them tonight.

EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - NIGHT

AERIAL: THE BEACH IN THE DARK. A LONG CURVE OF LANTERNS STRUNG BETWEEN THE BOATS, THREE HUNDRED PEOPLE ON THE SAND FACING THE SEA, AND ABOVE THEM ON THE DUNE THE DEAD MAST.

The generator hums behind the boats. The two loudspeakers stand at the waterline facing inland, their backs to the sea. Families on mats. Children asleep on laps. The church choir sits together, not singing. Latha, in uniform, stands at the back by her jeep.

Appachan sits in a plastic chair in the front row, Kannan at his feet. Anjali on the sand beside him. Rahul and Meenu at the Nagra, headphones on.

Anjali stands. The beach goes quiet.

ANJALI
My mother's name was Mariamma Thomas. Most of you knew her better than I did. I was eleven.
(beat)
This is the station's log tape from the fourteenth of November 1999. It runs fifty minutes. I haven't cut anything out.
(to Rahul)
Play it.

Over the speakers, huge: hiss. Rain on a roof twenty-three years ago. Then Mariamma's laugh.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
(over the speakers)
No, Joe, I'm not going to say it like that, they'll think somebody died...

Some of the old women laugh, they can't help it, and cover their mouths with the ends of their saris.

The tape runs. The tide creeps up the sand. Nobody leaves. On the tape, a heavy clunk, then a silence so complete that a child starts to cry and is hushed. Then, very small:

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
Little Flower, Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara, on battery.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
Kadalkkara, Little Flower. Weak, but I have you. Go.

In the front rows an old skipper stands up without meaning to. Then another.

Suresh stands and walks down to the speakers. At a nod from Anjali, Rahul brings the tape down low under him. It keeps running.

SURESH
Eleven boats went out that night.
(beat)
Little Flower. Seagull. Morning Star. Bismillah. Sea Queen. Ambadi. Jyothi. Mother Mary. St. Antony. Kairali. Pournami.

With each name, somewhere in the crowd, somebody stands. An old man. A widow. A boy in his grandfather's place.

SURESH (CONT'D)
Eight came home. They came home on my father's light. My father had it from Mariamma Thomas, who sat in the dark and talked to him on a battery after the Port switched her off.
(he looks at Anjali)
For twenty-three years we said the wrong thing about her. I said it loudest.

Rahul brings the tape back up.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
I'm going back for Hamza. Mariamma, I'm going back.

By her urn, Fathima closes her eyes.

At the edge of the lantern light Joe stands where he has stood for an hour, on the point of leaving. Latha comes and stands beside him.

LATHA
(low)
Stay to the end.

JOE
(low)
I was here for the end once before. I left.

LATHA
So stay this time.

He stays.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
Kadalkkara. Battery's going. Time is twenty-three fifty-one. Anjali's asleep.

Appachan turns his head toward the speakers, as if someone had called him from the next room.

APPACHAN
(clearly, to no one)
There she is.

Anjali takes his hand.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
I'll put the lantern on the jetty for you, Varghese. Look for the lantern.

The long hiss.

APPACHAN
(softly)
Good girl. Go on now. Go home.

He is smiling. His eyes are wet. He is at peace.

Fathima crouches beside Anjali.

FATHIMA
Rahul's on the roof. He says it's ready.

Anjali looks up at the dark station on the dune. A torch blinks twice on the roof.

EXT. COAST RADIO STATION - ROOF - NIGHT

A flat concrete roof, weeds in the cracks, the mast rising from one corner. Below: the lanterns, the people, the hum of the generator.

Rahul kneels by the biscuit-tin transmitter on an upturned fish crate. A heavy cable runs from it to the base of the mast on crocodile clips. A car battery beside it. The Nagra, carried up in its suitcase, lies open next to the tin, the reel rewound.

Anjali climbs up through the roof hatch.

RAHUL
I've matched it to the mast. It'll go ten kilometres. Fifteen if God's listening.

ANJALI
It's not legal.

RAHUL
It's not legal for one night.

He hands her the microphone: the Walkman microphone, taped to the handle of a wooden spoon.

ANJALI
What frequency?

RAHUL
Hers. The one inside the front cover of the log.

She looks out at the sea, black, the lights of a few far boats on it.

ANJALI
I've never done this.

RAHUL
You do it every day. You just take it out afterwards.

She keys the microphone.

ANJALI
(into the microphone)
All stations, all stations, this is Kadalkkara.
(her voice shakes; she lets it)
Kadalkkara coast radio, for the last time from this mast. Wind northwest, ten knots. Swell under a metre. Low tide at five fourteen.
(a breath)
What follows is a recording from the night of the fourteenth of November 1999. The operator is Mariamma Thomas.

She nods. Rahul pushes the lever. The reels turn, the lamp on the tin glows, and Mariamma's voice goes out through the old mast into the dark.

They sit with their backs against the parapet. Below them, the beach. Ahead, the sea, listening.

WIDE ON THE STATION FROM THE SEA: THE SMALL LIGHT ON THE ROOF, THE MAST, THE LANTERNS ALONG THE BEACH, ALL OF IT TINY UNDER THE STARS.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. COAST RADIO STATION - DAY

Morning. Hard sun. A hundred people behind the tape, quieter than a crowd should be. Police barricades. Latha's jeep on the track.

A yellow tracked excavator with a demolition grab crawls up the sand track. Suresh, in a hard hat and a high-visibility vest, walks round it once and signals his crew to clear the area.

Anjali stands at the tape with Appachan, in his good shirt again. Fathima on his other side. Kannan at their feet.

APPACHAN
What are they doing?

ANJALI
Taking it down.

APPACHAN
Is everyone home?

ANJALI
Everyone's home.

Suresh looks across. Anjali nods. He lifts his hand to the operator.

The arm rises, swings and bites into the first wall. Concrete groans and gives. Dust rolls out over the crowd. Fathima flinches. Appachan does not.

By noon the operations room is a hill of broken concrete. The grab works at the mast footings. The steel shrieks. The mast leans, slowly, and seems to stop, as if thinking about it.

WIDE ON THE MAST AS IT LEANS PAST THE POINT OF NO RETURN AND FALLS INTO THE COCONUT GROVE. PALM FRONDS BURST. CROWS GO UP IN A BLACK SHEET.

The ground shakes. Dust drifts over everything.

In the silence, Appachan claps his hands. Once. The sharp clap the men on the beach give when a boat comes in over the bar.

An old fisherman claps once too. Then a few more. Not applause. The clap for a boat coming in.

Suresh takes off his hard hat and walks over to the tape. He and Anjali stand on either side of it.

SURESH
That's it, then.

ANJALI
That's the building.

FATHIMA
(holding out a tumbler of tea to Suresh)
Drink. You look like a ghost.

CUT TO:

INT. FATHIMA'S TEA SHOP - DAY

The afternoon lull. Newspapers spread on the floor. Rahul kneels on them, painting white letters onto a long jackwood plank. Meenu outlines each one in blue. So far the plank says Low Tide Rad.

On the counter the biscuit-tin transmitter, scorched black down one side, has a cardboard sign in Meenu's writing: Do not touch. Historic.

Anjali sits at the corner table with her phone. Fathima wipes the same patch of counter for a long time.

STUDIO PRODUCER (ON PHONE)
I've held the detergent people a week, Anjali. They redid the voice. She sounds tired again. I need you back Monday.

ANJALI
I'm not coming back, Nikhil. I'll send notes on the open sessions. Tell the client she sounds tired because she's a person.

STUDIO PRODUCER (ON PHONE)
Is this about money? Because I can...

ANJALI
It's about breathing.
(beat)
Leave the breaths in. That's my last note.

She hangs up and puts the phone face down. Fathima keeps wiping.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
You can stop pretending you weren't listening.

FATHIMA
I wasn't listening. I'm cleaning.

ANJALI
That spot's very clean.

FATHIMA
It's a very dirty spot.
(beat)
So you're staying.

ANJALI
Somebody has to stop him setting the shop on fire.

RAHUL
(not looking up)
Once. Small fire.

Fathima puts the cloth down, comes round the counter, sits across from Anjali and says nothing at all, which for Fathima is a speech.

Rahul paints the last letter and sits back on his heels.

RAHUL (CONT'D)
Low Tide Radio.

MEENU
(critically)
The O is fat.

RAHUL
The O is perfect.

EXT. KADALKKARA HARBOUR - DAWN

Blue light. Engines cough and catch one after another down the wharf. Diesel smoke on the water. Men throw lines and jump aboard.

In every wheelhouse, a radio. Cheap transistors on shelves. A marine set on the Bismillah. A transistor hung from a nail on the Jyothi. From all of them at once, a little out of step, the same voice.

ANJALI (ON RADIO)
Good morning, Kadalkkara. This is Low Tide Radio with the weather for the boats. Wind east-northeast, eight knots, backing north by afternoon. Swell one metre. Visibility good.

On the Jyothi the Old Fisherman stops coiling a rope and turns the transistor up.

ANJALI (ON RADIO) (CONT'D)
Low tide at five forty...
(a rustle of paper)
No. Five fifty-two. Sorry, Raghavan. Don't come and shout at me.

The Old Fisherman laughs out loud, alone on his deck. On the radio Anjali laughs too. She lets it run. Nobody cuts it.

ANJALI (ON RADIO) (CONT'D)
(still laughing)
Go well. Come home.

The boats go out through the harbour mouth in a line, past the breakwater, into the light.

EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - DAY

Low tide. The sea has gone out a very long way. The wet sand shines like a mirror with the sky in it.

Anjali and Appachan walk along the water's edge, slowly, his arm through hers. Kannan runs ahead through the shallow pools, scattering crabs, runs back, runs ahead again.

Behind them, on the dune where the station stood, there is only sky, a heap of broken concrete and a stump of steel.

Anjali stops and looks at the watch on her wrist. 23:52. She pulls out the crown and winds it, turn after turn, then sets the hands to the morning. The second hand starts to move.

When she takes his arm again, Appachan hums. Four notes, wobbling. The station jingle from the cassette.

She hums it back.

They walk on. Behind them, their footprints fill with water.

FADE OUT.